THE ADHD MONEY SYSTEM YOU SET UP ONCE

Forget-Proof Money

You're not bad with money. You've been using systems that need a perfect memory. This one moves the remembering out of your head and into your bank.

4 setup sessions × 15 min

10 min a week after

no willpower required ✦

START HERE · 2-MINUTE READ

Why every budget you tried quit on you

Most budgets assume you will **remember** to check your balance, **remember** what's due, and **resist** the 11pm checkout button using pure willpower. Every single day.

ADHD is widely described as affecting executive functions: working memory, time management, and getting started on boring tasks. A system that depends on those exact things is a system designed to fail you. That's not a character flaw. It's a design flaw.

Forget-Proof Money runs on 3 rules

1. **Automate it.** If a task has to happen every month, a bank does it, not you.
2. **Shrink it to one number.** You only ever look at one account and one number: your **Safe-to-Spend**.
3. **Check in for 10 minutes.** Once a week, with a timer and a reward. That's the whole job.

How to use this kit

- [ ] Do the 4 setup sessions. Each one is 15 minutes. Do one a day, or all in one sitting if you're feeling it.
- [ ] Fill in the pages in pen, or use the spreadsheet (it does the maths for you).
- [ ] Stick the one-page Cheat Sheet (page 13) on your fridge or phone lock screen.
- [ ] Fall off? Go to the 15-Minute Restart (page 12). No starting over, no shame.

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SESSION 1 ⏱ 15 MIN

The Bill Dump

Get every regular payment out of your head and onto paper. Don't organise yet. Just dump. Open your banking app and scroll the last 60 days if your memory goes blank (it will, that's normal).

Prompt list: tick each one you pay

- ☐ Rent / mortgage
- ☐ Electric, gas, water
- ☐ Phone
- ☐ Internet
- ☐ Car payment / transport pass
- ☐ Car or renter's insurance
- ☐ Loan / credit card minimums
- ☐ Streaming & app subscriptions
- ☐ Gym / memberships
- ☐ Medication / prescriptions
- ☐ Childcare / pet costs
- ☐ Yearly ones (domain, Amazon Prime, car tax)

Bill	Amount	Due day	How often	Autopay?

More bills? Use the next page. Yearly bills: divide by 12 and write the monthly amount in brackets.

SESSION 1 · CONTINUED

Bill Dump, page 2 + your total

Bill	Amount	Due day	How often	Autopay?

Total monthly bills: $_____

Add up the monthly amounts (including yearly bills ÷ 12). This number powers everything else.

Done with Session 1? Reward yourself now, not later. Pick one: snack, a song, 10 minutes of whatever you were avoiding this for. Pairing a boring task with something you enjoy is a documented habit technique (researchers call it "temptation bundling"). Use it every session.

You just did the part most people never do. ✦

SESSION 2 ⏱ 15 MIN

The 4 Accounts

One account for everything means one big number that lies to you. You see $900, you feel rich, and rent is due Friday. Split it so every account has **one job**.

1 · Bills

Gets the bill money every payday. Autopay pulls from here. You never look at it or carry its card.

2 · Spend

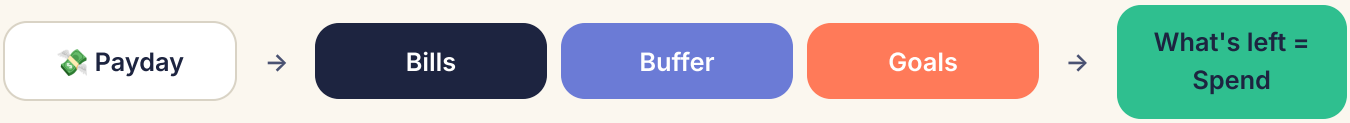
Your everyday debit card. Groceries, coffee, fun. The only balance you check.

3 · Buffer

Your "oops" money for surprise costs, so a vet bill doesn't break the whole system. Aim for one month of bills over time.

4 · Goals

Holiday, debt payoff, new laptop. Money with a name on it is harder to impulse-spend.



How to set it up

- [ ] Check whether your bank lets you open extra accounts or "pots/buckets" for free in the app. Many do. If not, a second free bank works fine.
- [ ] Name them exactly: **BILLS – don't touch**, **SPEND**, **BUFFER**, **GOALS – [your goal]**. Names do a lot of the willpower for you.
- [ ] Ask your employer (HR or payroll portal) whether you can split your direct deposit across accounts. If you can, money lands in the right place before you ever see it.
- [ ] If you can't split it, set **scheduled automatic transfers** for the day after payday.

SESSION 2 · WORKSHEET

Your payday split

I get paid: ☐ weekly ☐ every 2 weeks ☐ twice a month ☐ monthly ☐ it's irregular

Take-home pay per paycheck: $ _____

Paychecks per month: _____ (weekly ≈ 4.33 · every 2 weeks ≈ 2.17 · twice a month = 2 · monthly = 1)

Account	Per paycheck	How to work it out	Auto-transfer set?
Bills	$	Total monthly bills ÷ paychecks per month, then add 5% for safety	☐
Buffer	$	Start small: $10–25 is fine. Consistency beats size.	☐
Goals	$	Anything you like, even $5. You can raise it later.	☐
Spend	$	Pay − Bills − Buffer − Goals	(stays)

Worked example
Sam is paid $1,400 every 2 weeks. Monthly bills: $1,950.
Bills: $1,950 ÷ 2.17 ≈ $900 → add 5% = **$945** · Buffer **$25** · Goals **$30**
Spend: $1,400 − $945 − $25 − $30 = **$400 per paycheck**

Irregular income? Use your lowest month from the last 6 months as "pay". Anything above it goes straight to Buffer until Buffer holds one month of bills.

SESSION 3 ⏱ 15 MIN

Your Safe-to-Spend number

This is the only number you need to remember between paydays. If you're under it, you're fine. No categories, no tracking every coffee.

Safe-to-Spend per day =

Money in SPEND ÷ days until next payday

Sam's example
$400 in Spend · 14 days to payday
$400 ÷ 14 ≈ **$28.50 a day**
or about $200 a week

Yours
$ _____ ÷ _____ days
= $ _____ a day
= $ _____ a week

Make it impossible to forget

- [ ] Write your weekly number on a sticky note on your card, or snap a photo of the filled-in box on page 13 and make it your lock screen.
- [ ] Turn on your bank's balance alerts for the **SPEND** account only. Turn off alerts for everything else; less noise means you'll actually read them.
- [ ] Overspent one day? Don't fix the past. Just divide what's left by the days left. The number updates; the system keeps going.

One account. One number. That's it. ✦

SESSION 4 ⏱ 15 MIN

Autopay everything

Late fees, missed payments and forgotten renewals are what the ADHD community calls the "ADHD tax". This session is where you stop paying it.

- [ ] Go down your Bill Dump. For each bill without autopay, switch it on, paying **from the BILLS account**.
- [ ] Credit cards: set autopay to at least the **minimum payment**, so you never get a late fee even in a chaotic month.
- [ ] **Bill-day trick:** many providers let you change your due date if you ask. Move as many as you can to 2–5 days after payday. Script: *"Hi, can I change my payment due date to the [day] of each month?"*
- [ ] Add one repeating calendar alert, the day after payday: **"Check the transfers went through ✔"**. Two minutes. That's the only bill job left for you.
- [ ] Can't autopay something (e.g., paying a landlord in cash)? Put it in the calendar with **two alerts**: 3 days before and on the day.

Setup complete. From now on, your bills pay themselves from an account you never touch, your savings move automatically, and you only watch one number. Everything after this page is maintenance: 10 minutes a week.

EVERY WEEK ⏱ 10 MIN

The 10-Minute Money Date

Same day, same time, same treat. Set a phone timer for 10 minutes. When it rings, you're allowed to stop, even mid-step.

1. **Treat first.** Coffee, snack, a favourite playlist. This is a date, not a punishment.
2. **Check SPEND.** Balance ÷ days to payday = your new Safe-to-Spend. Write it down.
3. **Glance at BILLS.** Did autopays go out? Anything weird? (Just look. Don't fix yet.)
4. **Visit the Parking Lot** (next page). Anything unlocked that you still want?
5. **One win.** Write one thing that went right this week, even "I opened the app".

Date	Safe-to-Spend	Bills OK?	One win
		☐	
		☐	
		☐	
		☐	
		☐	
		☐	
		☐	
		☐	

My Money Date is every _____ at _____ with _____ (treat).

WHEN THE URGE HITS

The Impulse Parking Lot

You don't need more self-control. You need a gap between "I want it" and "I bought it". Don't say no. Say **"not yet"**: park it for 72 hours.

I want...	Price	Parked on	Unlocks on (+3 days)	Still want it?
				☐ yes ☐ no
				☐ yes ☐ no
				☐ yes ☐ no
				☐ yes ☐ no
				☐ yes ☐ no
				☐ yes ☐ no

Unlocked and still want it? Buy it with zero guilt, if it fits your Safe-to-Spend or your Goals account. The point isn't to stop buying. It's to only buy what you still want on day 3.

- [ ] Delete saved cards from the 2 shops you impulse-buy from most.
- [ ] Log out of shopping apps on your phone. The extra 30 seconds is a speed bump.

Monthly Subscription Sweep ⏱ 5 min

- [ ] Search your bank app for the last month's recurring charges.
- [ ] For each one, ask: did I use this in the last 30 days?
- [ ] Cancel one you didn't use. Do it now, while you're looking at it.
- [ ] Free trial? Cancel it the same day you start it. Most still give you the full trial.

GET YOUR "ADHD TAX" BACK

The late-fee call script

Many companies will remove a one-off late fee if you ask politely, especially if you're usually on time. It's not guaranteed, but asking costs you nothing but a few minutes. Read this word for word if your brain freezes.

You: "Hi, I noticed a late fee of $_____ on my account. I've set up autopay now so it won't happen again. Is there any way you could waive this one as a courtesy?"

If they say no: "I understand. Could you note on my account that I asked, and is there anyone else who could review it?"

If they say yes: "Thank you so much, I really appreciate it." Then write it below. 🎉

Company	Fee	Date called	Waived?
			☐
			☐
			☐

Prefer not to call? Most banking and utility apps have chat. Paste the script in. Same words, no phone anxiety.

FELL OFF? START HERE

The 15-Minute Restart

You missed three Money Dates. You haven't opened your bank app in a month. **Good news: the system kept running without you.** That's the whole point of it. Bills still paid, savings still moved. You're not starting over. You're just checking in.

1. **Treat + timer.** 15 minutes, then you're allowed to stop.
2. **Check BILLS.** Is there enough for the next bills? If not, move money from Buffer. That's literally what Buffer is for.
3. **New Safe-to-Spend.** Money in SPEND ÷ days to payday. Forget what happened before today.
4. **Any late fees?** Use the script on page 11.
5. **Book your next Money Date** in your calendar right now, before you close this page.

Missing a week doesn't break the system. Quitting the system does. You're here, so you didn't quit. ✦

PRINT ME · STICK ME ON THE FRIDGE

Forget-Proof Money: cheat sheet

BILLS
Autopay only. Never look.

SPEND
My card. My one number.

BUFFER
For "oops". Refill when used.

GOALS
Money with a name on it.

My Safe-to-Spend this week

$ _____

Every payday
✓ Transfers went through? (2 min)

Every week
✓ 10-Minute Money Date + treat

Every month
✓ Subscription Sweep (5 min)

Want something?
✓ Park it for 72 hours

Not "no". Just "not yet". ✦

THE SMALL PRINT

Please read

Educational only. Forget-Proof Money is general educational material about organising personal money. It is not financial, tax, legal or medical advice, and it doesn't consider your individual situation. For advice about debt, investments or taxes, speak to a qualified professional.

Not a treatment. This kit doesn't diagnose or treat ADHD or any other condition. If you're struggling, a doctor or licensed mental-health professional can help.

Banks differ. Features like extra accounts, split direct deposit, alerts, fee waivers and due-date changes depend on your bank, employer and providers. Check their terms and any fees before setting anything up.

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